School of Technology & Computing

AI on the Front Line

A field guide for Seattle-area police, fire & EMS — and the policies now catching up with it

Seattle · Greater Seattle · Washington State

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Contents

Why This Guide Exists

Tonight, on shift, officers, firefighters, and paramedics across the Seattle area are already using AI tools — often before their own department has published a policy governing how. The technology moved first. The rules are only now catching up, and they're arriving from three directions at once: city policy, county budgets, and a state task force with the authority to send binding recommendations straight to the legislature.

> *An independent, pre-registered randomized controlled trial tested AI-assisted report writing across 755 reports written by 85 officers at a mid-sized police department and found no statistically significant reduction in writing time — directly contradicting vendor marketing claims of an 82% time savings (Adams et al., Journal of Experimental Criminology, 2024).*
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> *In October 2024, the King County Prosecuting Attorney's Office — which handles every prosecution filed in the Seattle area — instructed local police not to use generative AI to write reports at all, warning that AI errors can be "so small that they will be missed in review" even though officers must attest to a report's accuracy under penalty of perjury (Electronic Frontier Foundation, Oct. 2024).*
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> *On July 1, 2026, the Washington State AI Task Force released its final report, capping two years and more than 75 public meetings with 11 total policy recommendations sent to the legislature and governor — including a requirement that law enforcement agencies publicly disclose which AI tools they use (Washington State Office of the Attorney General, July 1, 2026).*

This guide walks through what's actually happening, department by department and layer by layer, starting where the pressure is highest: Seattle Police Department.

1. Seattle Police: AI at the Keyboard and on Patrol

The push toward AI at Seattle Police Department started with a simple goal from Chief Sean Barnes: give officers back the roughly two hours they currently spend writing each incident report, and put that time back into the community instead. But in the months since, SPD's own research leadership has steered the conversation away from the report-writing pitch and toward a more defensible frame — AI as a quality-assurance and accountability layer, not a narrative-writing shortcut.

> *Axon markets its "Draft One" report-writing tool on the claim that officers spend up to 40% of a shift on paperwork it can help reduce (Axon, Draft One product page).*

What this looks like inside SPD

Rather than adopting an AI report-writer outright, SPD is building out a set of narrower, lower-risk tools first — each one designed so that AI never becomes the sole author of a signed, official document.

- CaseX/Corvus — a public-facing, AI-assisted online crime-reporting tool that has cleared privacy review; it walks a community member through filing their own report, which the citizen (not an officer) reviews and approves before it's submitted.
- Mark 43 QA prompts — a records-management vendor's new quality-assurance feature that checks a report for completeness (for example, flagging when a hospital transport is mentioned but not logged), rather than drafting any narrative language itself.

- A closed, SPD-specific AI deployment procured by the City, currently restricted to low-risk, public-data-only use cases while security, roles, and access permissions are finalized before any higher-risk use is considered.
- A planned natural-language-processing review tool intended to flag weak or poorly articulated reasonable-suspicion and probable-cause language for a supervisor's attention — built as a training and accountability check, not a drafting assistant.

None of this yet adds up to a published, department-wide AI policy — SPD's draft policy has cleared legal and privacy review and is currently with its policy unit. But it does mean SPD is further along on internal AI governance than any public document currently reflects.

2. The Line King County Prosecutors Drew

The single biggest constraint on AI-assisted report writing in the Seattle area isn't a police department policy at all — it's a prosecutor's memo.

> *"We do not fear advances in technology — but we do have legitimate concerns about some of the products on the market now," Chief Deputy Prosecuting Attorney Daniel J. Clark wrote in the King County Prosecuting Attorney's Office's October 2024 memo announcing it would not accept any police narrative produced with AI assistance (Electronic Frontier Foundation, Oct. 2024).*

Why this matters for the officer who signs it

An officer who signs an AI-assisted report is still attesting, under penalty of perjury, that its contents are accurate. If the AI invented a detail and the officer didn't catch it, that fabrication becomes Brady material — evidence favorable to the defendant that the prosecution is legally obligated to disclose (Brady v. Maryland, 1963; Cornell Law School's Legal Information Institute). Once that happens, the officer's credibility, and potentially the whole case, is exposed to challenge.

- Current AI report-drafting tools run at roughly 80% accuracy in practice — meaning about one in five outputs contains an error serious enough to matter in an official document.
- Documented failures elsewhere in the country include an AI-generated police report that invented a full statement from an officer who was never at the scene — an immediate Brady problem once it was signed (Futurism, Aug. 2024).
- King County's prohibition is explicitly framed as a "for now" position tied to the current state of the technology, not a permanent ban — leaving room for the policy to change as tools improve and as evaluation partners like CityU help departments test that improvement independently.
- The independent RCT covered above cuts against the strongest argument for these tools in the first place: if there's no proven time savings, the accuracy trade-off becomes much harder to justify.

3. Washington's AI Task Force: The Statewide Rules Taking Shape

Created by the legislature in 2024 through SB 5838, the Washington State AI Task Force brought together 19 members — government, industry, labor, civil rights groups, and academia — across eight subcommittees. Over two years and more than 75 meetings, it circulated draft recommendations to over 300 stakeholders before final public votes.

> *The task force's three reports (December 2024, December 2025, and the final report of July 1, 2026) together advance 11 policy recommendations. Lawmakers introduced legislation addressing eight of them during the 2025–2026 biennium and have enacted four in whole or in part — including a requirement that law enforcement agencies disclose their AI use (Washington State Office of the Attorney General, July 1, 2026).*

What it means for an officer on shift

Recommendation 3, approved by the task force's Public Safety Subcommittee, requires law enforcement agencies to publicly disclose which AI systems they use, and requires any officer who uses AI to help draft a report to personally review and attest that its contents are entirely accurate before submitting it. Disclosure requirements scale with agency size, so a small rural department isn't held to Seattle PD's infrastructure standard — but the human-oversight requirement is universal.

- Public disclosure — agencies must publish which AI tools they deploy and how they're used (Recommendation 3, approved and before the legislature).
- Officer attestation — the officer, not the software vendor, carries the professional and legal liability for anything they sign, AI-assisted or not.
- Bargaining rights are still pending, not enacted: HB 1622 would give public-sector workers, including first responders, the right to bargain over AI adoption before deployment. It passed the Washington House 58–38 in March 2025, was reintroduced in January 2026, and remained in House Rules Committee review as of this writing — it has not yet passed the Senate (Washington State Legislature bill history, HB 1622).
- Governance model — the task force formally adopted the NIST AI Risk Management Framework, with an added emphasis on "public purpose and social benefit" for government use, as its foundational model.

4. Fire & Wildfire: Washington's AI Camera Network

Washington's wildfire season increasingly leans on AI to buy fire crews the only resource they can't manufacture on their own: minutes.

> *The Washington Department of Natural Resources, partnered with Pano AI and T-Mobile, expanded its AI-assisted wildfire camera network to 36 stations statewide in 2026, up from 26 — each station's paired 360-degree cameras feeding footage to Pano AI analysts who alert DNR's dispatch center the moment smoke or fire is detected, often well ahead of the first 911 call (The Seattle Times, 2026).*

What this looks like for local fire agencies

These cameras support DNR-coordinated wildland response, which King County-area fire agencies plug into through the state's mutual aid system during fire season. Structural fire response — the more common call for Seattle Fire Department — is a separate problem with far less public AI infrastructure behind it so far.

- Because each camera station can be triangulated, DNR can dispatch resources to a precise latitude and longitude instead of a general area — shrinking the time between detection and boots on the ground.
- Seattle Fire Department is one of six City of Seattle departments currently running an AI pilot under the City's 2025–2026 AI Plan, though no dedicated, published AI policy specific to fire operations exists yet.
- That same city plan commits to workforce upskilling for public-safety AI uses, including 911 translation services — a pillar that, as of this guide, has not yet been fully operationalized (City of Seattle, 2025–2026 AI Plan).
- The counter-check worth naming: Pano AI's own stated goal is to reliably detect 95%+ of fires within 15 minutes "with a manageable number of false positives" — a company target, verified internally through

human analyst review of each alert, not an independent, peer-reviewed evaluation (Pano AI, product overview).

5. EMS & 911: Where Seconds and Translation Both Matter

In EMS, AI's upside and its risk sit closer together than almost anywhere else in public safety — the same second AI can save, a mistranslation can cost.

> *In an early evaluation of the Corti dispatch-assist AI in Copenhagen's emergency call center, the system identified out-of-hospital cardiac arrest from call audio with roughly 95% accuracy, compared to about 73% for trained human dispatchers working alone — and did so faster (EENA/Corti evaluation report, 2020; World Economic Forum).*

The failure mode nobody puts in the pitch deck

AI-assisted translation of emergency calls has been documented to drop or flatten critical medical terms before they reach the responding crew. A symptom described in one language as urgent chest pressure can be rendered simply as "discomfort" — a translation failure that changes how a call gets triaged before a single paramedic is dispatched (PMC/NIH review of AI-mediated medical interpreting).

- Seattle & King County's EMS system, built around Medic One since the early 1970s, remains one of the longest-running paramedic programs in the country and still routes life-threatening calls through human-set dispatch triage guidelines.
- AI dispatch-assist and translation platforms are not confirmed in current local 911 center use, but they are the direction the technology is heading nationally — Baltimore's 911 center selected the Prepared AI platform for live call transcription, translation, and analytics in January 2025 (Business Wire, Jan. 2025).
- No published AI governance framework specific to Seattle Fire or King County EMS currently exists, unlike the disclosure and attestation rules that now formally cover law enforcement statewide.

The counter-checks worth reading before you buy

- Corti's 95%-vs-73% cardiac arrest figure comes from an early evaluation of roughly 161,650 calls in Copenhagen — but the full study was never published, so the rate of false positives it produced is still unknown. As World Economic Forum AI lead Kay Firth-Butterfield put it at the time: "This is another example of the need to test and verify algorithms" (World Economic Forum, 2018).
- Prepared's own presenters have publicly acknowledged that live call transcription runs "north of 85%, getting close to 90%" accuracy — not higher — and translation errors have been observed in practice, including a mistranslated version of the platform's own standard 911 opening prompt during a public demonstration (Citizen Portal AI, conference coverage).

6. Redmond PD: The Small-Department Pattern

The most concrete, already-running example of AI investigative work in the Seattle area isn't Seattle's own department — it's a King County suburb roughly the size of a large high school district.

> *Redmond Police Chief Darrell Lowe told KING 5 that the department's AI investigative tool, Longeye, sifted through 60 hours of jail phone records from a cold case and surfaced a confession within minutes — work*

> *Lowe estimated would otherwise have consumed a week and a half of an investigator's time, full time (MyNorthwest/KIRO Newsradio, Oct. 27, 2025).*

What Redmond did differently

Longeye is explicitly built not to create or predict information. It prioritizes and surfaces evidence investigators have already collected, guiding them toward the most relevant material rather than drafting anything on their behalf, according to the company's own co-founder — a distinction that keeps this use case out of the report-authorship gray zone entirely.

- Chief Lowe was direct in public comments: "AI will not replace the need for actual officers or investigators" — a framing that echoes SPD's own QA-first strategy rather than a narrative-generation pitch.
- Redmond's use case — investigative evidence review — sits in the lowest-risk tier under the emerging state framework, since no AI-authored content ever enters a signed report.
- It's a preview of scale: evidence-analysis tools like Longeye are being adopted by agencies nationally, well ahead of any governance policy built to catch up with them — by 2026, the company reports its tool has processed roughly 25 million files across 35 law enforcement agencies at the local, state, and federal level (The Washington Post, Apr. 10, 2026).
- That same reporting includes real skepticism: like any large language model, Longeye can still generate incorrect or misleading output ("hallucinations"), critics have drawn parallels to facial recognition's history of contributing to wrongful arrests, and courts haven't yet settled when an AI tool's role in an investigation must be disclosed to the defense (The Washington Post, Apr. 10, 2026).

7. King County Government Catches Up

While individual departments experiment tool by tool, King County's executive branch is building the governance layer meant to sit underneath all of them.

> *King County's proposed 2026–2027 budget dedicates nearly $3 million to a new countywide AI policy, including a $1 million AI Innovation Fund intended to protect privacy, prevent bias, protect workers, and promote responsible innovation across county departments (King County Executive's Office budget announcement; King County Council budget approval release, Nov. 18, 2025).*

Why a countywide layer matters for first responders

King County Sheriff's Office, Medic One, and the county's 911 Program Office all sit inside this same budget and policy structure. Once finalized, the countywide AI policy will likely set the governance baseline for county-run public safety agencies, even as city departments like SPD and SFD continue building their own department-specific rules in parallel.

- County agencies are expected to submit proposals to King County IT in early 2026 for the Innovation Fund to evaluate and select.
- This county-level layer sits alongside, not in place of, the prosecutor's existing prohibition on AI-assisted narratives and the state task force's disclosure and attestation requirements.
- No single department is being asked to solve AI governance alone — city, county, and state layers are all moving at the same time, which is exactly why a shared vocabulary and shared training matter.

How CityU's School of Technology & Computing Builds These Skills

Every gap surfaced in this guide — testing a vendor's accuracy claims before they reach a budget request, building a department's AI-literacy program, drafting attestation language that holds up in court — is a learnable skill set, not a slogan. CityU's School of Technology & Computing trains working professionals to do exactly this kind of work, without requiring them to put a career on pause to do it.

- Master of Science in Artificial Intelligence (MSAI) — a fully online, 39–59 credit program covering AI programming, machine learning and deep learning, natural language processing, agent-based systems, cloud computing, and applied ethics, capped by a real-world capstone project (cityu.edu, MSAI program page).
- The program's stated learning outcomes include applying AI principles to real use cases and using critical and ethical thinking to solve AI problems — the same evaluation skill set a department needs to test a vendor's "82% time savings" claim before it shows up in next year's budget.
- CityU's School of Technology & Computing also houses its Center for Cybersecurity Innovation, extending into the data-security and CJIS-adjacent questions that come up throughout this guide — from closed AI deployments to protected-data handling.

Your Next Step

You don't need a 90-day rollout plan to start. Every department furthest along in this guide started the same way: one honest inventory of what's already running on shift, and one conversation about where the gaps are. If you're weighing whether AI belongs in your department's next report, dispatch console, or investigative file, CityU's School of Technology & Computing would be glad to talk through what that first step looks like for your team — no pressure, no sales pitch, just a conversation with people who study this for a living.

CityU can plug in at whatever stage your department is at right now:

- Research partner — an independent, third-party evaluator for AI tools already entering your department, combining technologists and social scientists so findings hold up to scrutiny from every direction, including skeptics.
- Workshops & seminars — a facilitated, no-laptop-required session for command staff, union reps, and frontline personnel covering what AI tools are already in use, what the state now requires, and where your department's biggest gaps are.
- Microcredentialing — short, stackable AI-literacy credentials for officers, supervisors, and command staff that count toward professional development hours, without requiring anyone to pause their career for a full degree.

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